

Statement by Mexico on behalf of the New Agenda Coalition at the First Committee: General Debate

New York, 4 October 2023

October 2023

I have the honor to take the floor on behalf of the members of the New Agenda Coalition (NAC), Brazil, Egypt, Ireland, New Zealand, South Africa, and my own country, Mexico. At the outset, the NAC congratulates you on your assumption of your role as Chair of this year's First Committee. We assure you of the NAC's full cooperation.

Mr. President,

This year, the NAC commemorates twenty-five years since the Dublin Declaration on “A Nuclear Weapons-Free World: the Need for a New Agenda”, which established our initiative. Since 1998, the NAC has never wavered in its advocacy of nuclear disarmament negotiations. In so doing, the NAC has emphasized the moral and ethical underpinnings of the fulfillment of disarmament obligations and commitments that all States Parties to the NPT, in particular the Nuclear-Weapon States, must abide by.

We recognize there have been certain accomplishments in nuclear disarmament since the year of our founding. But the reality is that the achievement, let alone maintenance, of a world free of nuclear weapons, is still pending, and so must still be an urgent priority of the international community.

We note with deep concern, therefore, the profound global peace and security challenges we are facing today. We are alarmed that recent international tensions, including within the context of the conflict in Ukraine, have taken an increasing nuclear dimension, particularly with regard to threats to use nuclear weapons and increasingly strident nuclear rhetoric, which we unequivocally condemn. We underline the dangers this brings –occurring as it does against the backdrop of the

nuclear-weapon States and States under extended nuclear security guarantees giving increased prominence to maintaining and even increasing the role of nuclear weapons in security doctrines, as well as the placement of nuclear weapons on the territory of non-nuclear-weapon States. We have noted for some time the plans by the nuclear-weapon States to expand, modernize and qualitatively improve their nuclear arsenals. Alongside this, there are now disturbing signs that nuclear weapons stockpiles are increasing. Other negative developments include the weakening of the disarmament and non-proliferation architecture, including the erosion or demise of existing nuclear arms control treaties and the continuing disregard of the need to strengthen negative security assurances.

In this context, we are dismayed at the successive failures of the two most recent Review Conferences of the NPT. State Parties to the Treaty were unable to agree actions that would strengthen the NPT regime by consensus. The inability of the working group on further strengthening the review process of the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons to agree on substantive outcomes and recommendations was of further concern, and did not reflect the groundswell of support evident for this work.

The NAC reiterates that the existing nuclear disarmament-related obligations and commitments remain valid, including the unequivocal undertaking of the Nuclear-Weapon States to accomplish the total elimination of their nuclear arsenals leading to nuclear disarmament. Accordingly, NAC will continue to advocate for the implementation of concrete, transparent, mutually reinforcing, verifiable and irreversible nuclear disarmament measures as part of the fulfilment of NPT obligations and commitments.

We continue to express deep concern at the catastrophic humanitarian consequences that would result from any use of nuclear weapons. Ultimately, humanitarian imperatives underpin nuclear disarmament and the urgency of achieving it, especially when new evidence, such as the highly disproportionate and gendered impact of exposure to

ionizing radiation for women and girls, amongst other effects, is taken into account.

In 1995, the basis for the indefinite extension of the NPT was, and remains, “permanence with accountability”. It is critical that within the current review cycle of the Treaty we collectively advance measures on the agreements of the 1995, 2000 and 2010 Review Conferences on the NPT, in particular, the “13 steps” on nuclear disarmament.

We urge the Nuclear Weapon States to implement all their nuclear disarmament obligations and commitments, in a manner that strengthens accountability and enables all States parties to regularly monitor progress, thereby enhancing transparency and increasing mutual confidence. This would also facilitate the evidence-based evaluation of progress towards the full implementation of article VI and nuclear disarmament commitments.

Measures to this end should include improved reporting by the nuclear-weapon States, ideally through a standard detailed format with concrete and detailed information concerning implementation of their obligations and commitments. It should also include details on their plans related to the modernization of nuclear weapons; their nuclear capabilities including quantity, type and status of nuclear warheads, as well as delivery vehicles; doctrinal issues; risk reduction measures; de-alerting measures; quantity of fissile material; and the number and type of weapons and delivery systems they disarmed. It should also include other tools such as a set of benchmarks, timelines and/or similar criteria, in order to ensure and facilitate the objective evaluation of progress.

Mr. President,

One highlight is the consolidation of the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons (TPNW) regime, with positive steps to universalize the TPNW and implement its action plan adopted last year in Vienna.

We commend those states that recognize the TPNW for what it is – as an “effective measure” for nuclear disarmament, one fully consistent with and complementing the NPT. We further encourage all States to participate in its Second Meeting of State Parties, whether as State Parties or Observers.

We are also encouraged by the successful organization in 2019, 2021 and 2022 by the Secretary General of the UN, in accordance with its decision 73/546 of 22 December 2018, of the sessions of a conference aimed at elaborating a treaty on the establishment of a Middle East zone free of nuclear weapons and all other weapons of mass destruction, on the basis of arrangements freely arrived at by the States of the region. The NAC encourages all concerned parties referred in the decision to actively engage in the 2023 and ensuing sessions of the Conference.

Mr. President,

The NPT is the cornerstone of the nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation regime. But there is a deficit growing in terms of implementation of the Article 6 obligation and nuclear disarmament-related commitments by the Nuclear Weapon States. To preserve the credibility and strength of the Treaty, the Nuclear Weapon States must implement their respective obligations and commitments in full and without continued delay and therefore redress the imbalance in implementation with regard to Non-Nuclear Weapon States.

Any presumption of indefinite possession of nuclear weapons runs counter to the object and purpose of the Treaty, and any threat of use nuclear weapons, is contrary to the Charter of the UN and the multiple resolutions adopted each year by the General Assembly.

I thank you.

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